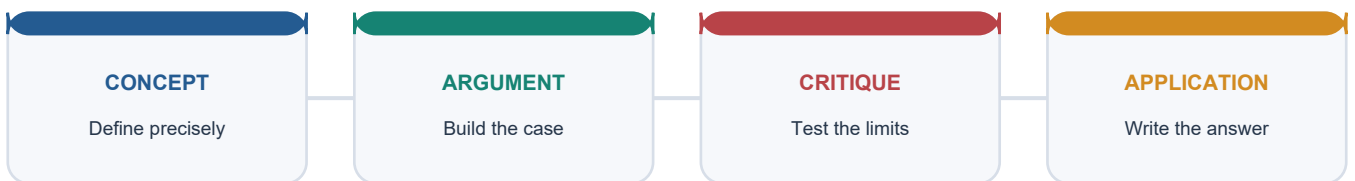


COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

UPSC Qualifying English - Practice Solutions

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

UPSC Qualifying English - Practice Solutions

Matching keys, model responses and self-marking guidance for every paper in the practice workbook.

PART 01 - 01 Foundation-Test-Key

Award credit for any grammatically correct answer that preserves the stated meaning. This key identifies a preferred examination form; it does not turn accepted modern formal English into an error.

A. Function in context

1. noun
2. pronoun
3. adjective
4. adverb
5. verb
6. determiner

B. Nouns and pronouns

1. *One of the applicants has withdrawn.* [AGR/CNT]
2. *The police are investigating the complaint.* [AGR]
3. *She gave me two useful pieces of advice.* [CNT]
4. *We bought three pieces of furniture for the office.* [CNT]
5. *Between you and me, the proposal is unsafe.* [PRO]
6. *Every applicant must bring their identity card.* [PRO] his or her and a clear plural recast also receive credit.
7. *The report that identified the error was published yesterday.* [REL]
8. No change: the clause identifies which candidates. [PRO/REL]
9. *The committee has submitted its report as one body.* [AGR]
10. *The scissors are on the table.* [AGR]

C. Agreement, tense, conditionals, articles and determiners

1. *A number of students are absent.* [AGR]
2. *Neither the manager nor the clerks are ready.* [AGR]
3. *The news is encouraging.* [AGR]
4. *She finished the report yesterday.* [TNS]
5. *By the time we arrived, the meeting had already ended.* [TNS]
6. *I know the answer now.* [TNS]
7. *If I had known, I would have called.* [COND]
8. *If she had accepted the post, she would live in Mumbai now.* [COND]
9. *When I arrive, I will call you.* [TNS]
10. *He went to the hospital to visit his friend.* [ART]
11. *She is a teacher in a village school.* [ART]
12. *Honesty is the best policy.* [ART]
13. No change. Few means scarcely any; a few means some. [ART]
14. No change: article choice follows sound. [ART]

D. Prepositions, verb patterns, phrasal verbs, conjunctions and modifiers

1. *She agreed to the proposal.* [PREP]
2. *The officer discussed the proposal.* [PREP]
3. *The unit comprises five sections. / The unit consists of five sections.*

[PREP]

4. *I have been waiting for three hours.* [PREP]
5. *We must comply with the order.* [PREP]
6. *The office provided meals for/to the workers.* [PREP]
7. *She turned it down without explanation.* [PHR]
8. *Although it was late, they continued.* [CONJ]
9. *The job requires planning, coordination and monitoring.* [PAR]
10. *While I was walking to the office, it began to rain.* [MOD] Equivalent

repairs that give the walker as the modifier's subject receive credit.

E. Punctuation, capitals and spelling

1. *After the interview, we returned home.*
2. *The proposal was ambitious; however, it lacked funding.* A full stop before However is also accepted.
3. *The reports that were incomplete were returned.* No commas: the clause is restrictive.
4. *Riya has only one brother, who lives in Pune.*
5. *The causes of the crisis are unemployment, inflation and weak demand.*

A consistent serial comma is also accepted.

6. *The officer's report was delayed.*
7. *No, the answer is not correct.*
8. *The inquiry had one conclusion: postpone the launch.*
9. *It's important to check every candidate's identity card.*
10. *The accommodation was definitely insufficient.*

F. Word formation, confusables and exact vocabulary

1. decision 2. alleviate 3. discreet 4. affect 5. stationery
6. principle 7. *abundant; plentiful* is accepted in a suitable sense
8. *wise or judicious*; another exact formal near-synonym is accepted
9. Award one mark only where the sentence shows "practicable/capable of being done": e.g., *The engineer proved that the bridge was feasible within the budget.*
10. Award one mark only where it means improperly reducing standards to save time/money: e.g., *The contractor cut corners on safety.*

G. Correction and accepted variants

1. **Acceptable.** Singular *their* is accepted modern formal English; *'his or her'* or plural recasting is also correct. [VAR]
2. ****Acceptable** in modern English, but avoid in a conservative correction test. **** Preferred safe rewrite:** *The reason is that funding was delayed.* Do not call the original objectively ungrammatical. [VAR]
3. **Acceptable.** *Angry at the contractor and angry with the contractor* are both standard. [VAR]
4. **Acceptable**, especially in North American usage. Conservative Indian formal alternatives: *provided the workers with meals / provided meals for the workers.* [VAR]
5. **Acceptable.** The collective noun refers to members acting separately; the plural pronoun matches. [VAR]

H. Transformations

1. *No sooner had the meeting ended than the members left.*
2. *Unless you revise, you will forget the rules.*
3. *The box is too heavy for me to lift.*
4. *In spite of being tired, he continued working.* / *In spite of the fact that he was tired, he continued working.*
5. *The accused was arrested by the police.* Agent omission is accepted.
6. *Riya was given a prize by the board.* / *A prize was given to Riya by the board.*
7. *He said (that) he was ready.* *is ready* may be accepted if the report is immediate and the state continues; the context should normally decide.
8. *The teacher asked/told Riya not to leave early.*
9. *The guide said that the Earth moves around the Sun.*
10. *Ravi solved only the problem.* Award only if the revised sentence clearly limits Ravi's action/object rather than the solver.

I. Meaning, use and tags

For 1-5, award one mark only for both a correct meaning and natural use:

1. *at sea* = confused/uncertain.
2. *a thorn in the flesh* = persistent source of irritation.
3. *move heaven and earth* = make every possible effort.
4. *A stitch in time saves nine* = prompt action prevents a larger problem.
5. *All that glitters is not gold* = appearances can mislead.
6. *won't they?* 7. *shall we?* 8. *is she?* 9. *will you?*
10. *isn't there?*

Scoring and diagnosis

Score **85**. For B-H, withhold credit only for a changed meaning, a grammatical error, or a form outside the acceptance guidance above. Record the question number and error code. The retry thresholds in the test apply to the revised 85-mark total as follows: **77-85** proceed; **68-76** targeted retry; **below 68** or a critical-section zero requires Core review and a fresh timed attempt. Two consecutive 77+ attempts are required before the full mock.

PART 02 - 02 Full-Length-Mock-Key

Q1. Essay: anchored internal bands

Criterion	80-100	60-79	Below 60
Relevance and thesis (20)	Direct, qualified thesis sustained	Relevant but broad or uneven	Drifts, repeats prompt or takes no position
Organisation (20)	Logical continuous argument; purposeful paragraphs	Basic sequence with repetition	List-;like or disordered
Development and balance (25)	Mechanisms, safe examples and genuine limitation	Some explanation, thin balance	Assertion, padding or invented evidence
Grammar and vocabulary (25)	Consistently clear and controlled	Noticeable but non-;blocking errors	Persistent errors obscure meaning
Conclusion and count (10)	Reasoned verdict; about 600 words	Abrupt or imprecise count	No conclusion or serious length failure

Prompt-specific planning anchors

These are planning routes, not memorisable essays. No Core model answers any Mock 1 prompt; score the script by the band descriptors rather than phrase matching.

Prompt	Qualified thesis	Four distinct moves
Convenience without responsibility...	Convenience can improve access, but citizenship weakens when people enjoy public benefits while disregarding their shared costs.	access; hidden costs; habits of responsibility; fair institutional design
Efficiency is not the same as effectiveness.	Efficiency conserves time and resources, but effectiveness asks whether the intended public or human outcome has actually been achieved.	distinction; useful speed; proxy-;measurement risk; outcome-;based correction
Certainty can be a barrier to learning.	Provisional confidence permits action, but unexamined certainty closes inquiry, evidence and correction.	value of conviction; how certainty blocks listening; disciplined doubt; reasoned conclusion
Reading is an exercise in freedom.	Reading enlarges freedom by revealing alternatives, although this depends on literacy, time and intellectual openness.	imagination; independent judgement; access limits; responsible freedom

Model-quality paragraph, not a prewritten essay: *An office may process a large number of applications quickly and still fail the people it serves. If applicants receive automatic messages but cannot correct an error, the system has become efficient at movement rather than effective at service. Speed remains valuable because delay has costs; however, the relevant test is whether the application reaches a fair and usable outcome. Measures should therefore track completion and correction, not merely disposal.* This models claim -> mechanism -> illustration -> qualification. It must be adapted, not copied.

Q2. Model points and practice splits

1. Construction produces a visible asset (5) and an occasion for inauguration (4), whereas maintenance is repetitive and dispersed (3) and therefore less publicly celebrated (3).
2. Small defects first reduce a system's resilience (5). Under heavy rain, high demand or emergency, weaknesses interact (5); the apparent sudden failure is thus accumulated ordinary neglect, not a single event (5).
3. **Financial (7):** capital and maintenance are planned separately (3); funds for staff, parts, supervision and renewal are unpredictable (4). **Institutional (8):** responsibility is fragmented (3), agencies assume another will act (2), and no official has both authority and incentive to repair the defect (3).
4. It means a system records acknowledgement or a registration number while no repair occurs (7). User information becomes effective only with a simple channel (2), acknowledgement (2) and published or visible corrective action (4).
5. **Title:** "Maintenance Is Public Service", "The Ethics of Maintenance", or another title covering the central claim (4). The attitude is strongly approving and corrective (2): maintenance protects past expenditure and prevents harm (4), extends scarce assets (2) and is equitable for people without private alternatives (3).

Q3. Model précis

Count record: source 458 words; one-third target about 153 words; model 155 words. The count excludes the candidate instruction to record rough-work counts. This is a practice calculation, not a published tolerance.

Modern life often equates speed with competence because rapid communication and delivery can save lives, cut costs and connect people. Yet valuable decisions require attention, verification and judgement. In medicine, justice and journalism, action without adequate evidence can cause harm that later correction cannot undo. Digital systems intensify this risk by making approval, sharing and acceptance effortless while leaving responsibility unchanged. Institutions must distinguish idle delay, caused by neglect or pointless procedure, from deliberation, which gathers evidence, compares claims and records reasons. They should remove waiting but protect stages where thought improves decisions. They must also ensure that difficult cases are not discarded merely to improve figures. Measures based only on closures, examinations or turnover can reward superficial completion instead of real outcomes. Individuals also need pauses before forwarding claims, reacting in anger or making irreversible choices. The alternative to haste is not procrastination but disciplined timeliness: acting when knowledge, authority and safeguards are sufficient.

Accept accurate, coherent versions close to the instructed proportion. Deduct diagnostically for omitted concessions, unsupported additions, copied wording, disconnected notes, wrong title instruction or material count failure.

Q4

A

1. One of the files **is** missing.
2. capable **of solving**
3. discussed the proposal
4. **Preferred conservative examination edit:** Neither of the alternatives **is** acceptable. **Variant policy:** *Neither alternative is acceptable* earns full credit. Plural *are* after *neither of* is documented in modern use and may be credited only where the test's declared house style accepts it; for this conservative correction test, prefer singular **is**.
5. returned from Delhi
6. furniture ... **is**
7. waiting **for** three hours
8. No sooner **had** the bell rung than...
9. **Preferred conservative examination edit:** The reason is **that** funding was delayed. **Variant policy:** *The reason is because funding was delayed* occurs in modern English but may be rejected as redundant by conservative examination keys; credit it only under a documented house style that accepts it. *Funding was delayed because...*

is a fully acceptable recast when a rewrite rather than minimal correction is permitted.

10. Each candidate must bring **his or her** admit card. Singular **their** is accepted where the sentence is otherwise clear and consistent; do not penalise it merely for being gender-neutral.

B

with, from, for, from, on

C

had ended; works; was reading; moves; has been serving

D

opaque, abundant, compulsory, flexible, permanent

Q5

A

1. The survey was completed by the team.
2. She said that she had submitted the form.
3. Hardly had the rain stopped when work resumed.
4. Unless you listen, you will misunderstand.
5. He was too weak to walk.
6. He is not only honest but also efficient.
7. In spite of the task being difficult, she completed it.
8. aren't they?
9. **It being a holiday, the office was closed.**
10. Meera checked only the accounts.

Equivalent grammatical transformations that preserve tense, agent and meaning should be accepted. Do not accept a dangling construction in which the **office** is represented as “being a holiday.”

B. Meaning, form and self-marking boundary

Word	Required form and meaning	Natural model sentence	Accept /​ reject
prudent	adjective: wisely cautious; showing good judgement	<i>A prudent applicant kept copies of every document.</i>	Accept a clear adjective use meaning cautious/​judicious; reject “careful” if context does not show judgement.
alleviate	transitive verb: make pain, hardship or severity less	<i>The extra water supply helped alleviate the shortage.</i>	Accept correct inflections; reject “eliminate completely” or noun use where a verb is required.
reluctant	adjective, commonly <i>reluctant to + verb</i> : unwilling or hesitant	<i>Reluctant to sign without evidence, she asked for time.</i>	Accept unwilling/​hesitant; reject “eager” or a sentence where hesitation is absent.
impartial	adjective: fair; not favouring either side	<i>An impartial officer heard both complaints before deciding.</i>	Accept neutral/​fair if the sentence demonstrates equal treatment; reject “uninterested” when it means careless.
feasible	adjective: practicable or capable of being done	<i>The engineer showed that the repair was feasible within the available time.</i>	Accept practicable/​viable; reject merely “desirable” or an adverb/​noun substitution.

C

complement, stationery, principle, affect, discreet

D. Meaning, form and self-marking boundary

Expression	Meaning and form	Natural model sentence	Accept /​ reject
at sea	idiomatic adjective phrase: confused or uncertain	<i>Without the map, I was at sea.</i>	Accept uncertainty/​confusion; reject a literal sea voyage unless the figurative meaning is also clear.
cut corners	verb phrase: save time/​money improperly by lowering standards	<i>The contractor cut corners on safety checks.</i>	Reject efficient economy that does not imply improper reduced standards.
a blessing in disguise	noun phrase: an apparent setback later proves beneficial	<i>The delayed launch was a blessing in disguise because it exposed the fault.</i>	Reject an event that is simply pleasant from the beginning.
A stitch in time saves nine	proverb: early action prevents a larger problem	<i>The clerk repaired the minor error at once; a stitch in time saves nine.</i>	A complete proverb may stand alone; reject use that implies delay is preferable.
All that glitters is not gold	proverb: attractive appearance can conceal poor value	<i>The impressive offer carried hidden costs; all that glitters is not gold.</i>	A complete proverb may stand alone; reject literal use without the cautionary meaning.

PART 03 - 03 Full-Length-Mock-2-Key

Q1. Essay rubric

Use the Mock 1 anchored bands. A high-band answer decodes the exact proposition, states a qualified thesis in the introduction, develops distinct mechanisms, tests a real limitation, uses safe examples analytically and finishes near 600 words with a reasoned verdict.

Planning anchors

Prompt	Defensible qualified thesis
Rules acquire legitimacy...	Enforcement is necessary, but a rule gains durable legitimacy when people can understand its purpose, application and route of challenge.
The ability to listen...	Listening is public responsibility because decisions affect people unequally; it requires conditions for informed dissent, not passive silence.
Progress should enlarge...	Progress is incomplete if more options are offered without the education, time and institutions needed for considered judgement.
A city is made...	Buildings enable urban life, but shared habits of care, rule-​following and coexistence determine whether the city remains liveable.

Q2. Model points and practice splits

1. The data must be accurate (3), carefully interpreted (4), connected to a decision (4), and owned by someone responsible for making that decision (4).
2. A record can be factually accurate yet measure an inadequate proxy rather than the relevant outcome (8). For example, attendance does not establish learning, or clinic visits do not establish completed treatment (7).
3. Numbers are simplified representations and should not be mistaken for the fuller lived condition they measure (8). In public services this can reward an attractive number while excluding unmeasured harm, especially for people unable to complain or switch services (7).

4. The tone is **qualified and cautionary**, not anti-data **(3)**. Targets can clarify purpose and improve performance **(6)**, but can distort behaviour when the number is rewarded instead of the purpose **(6)**.
5. Suitable titles include “*Measure Without Losing Meaning*” or “*Data Needs Judgement*” **(4)**. The examples show, across education, health and transport, that a single number can miss the service outcome it is meant to represent **(6)**; they make the abstract warning concrete **(3)** and demonstrate that the problem applies across public institutions **(2)**.

Q3. Model précis

Count record: source **246** words; one-third target **about 82** words; model **83** words.

Silence in public life cannot safely be treated as consent because it may reflect agreement, fear, confusion or exclusion. A formal invitation to comment does not ensure that participants can influence a decision: they may lack confidence, technical language or belief that dissent matters. Listening therefore requires checking understanding, representation, candid formats and minority reasons. Although action cannot await unanimity and may sometimes be urgent, institutions should distinguish informed acceptance from silence caused by exclusion so that firm decisions remain open to correction.

Q4

A

1. The list of eligible candidates **is** displayed outside.
2. She has been living here **for** five years.
3. The report was divided **into** four sections.
4. He insisted **on inspecting** the original file.
5. Neither Rohan nor his friends **were** willing to wait.
6. The manager suggested **that I apply again** / suggested **applying again**.
7. Having finished the audit, **the auditors reported the errors**.
8. I prefer walking **to** taking a crowded bus.
9. Every employee should submit **his or her** form. Singular **their** is also acceptable if the remainder is clear and consistent.
10. The committee discussed the delay.

B

to, with, on, of, from

C

leaves; was preparing; will have completed; seems; have not seen

D

accidental, contract, reveal, superior, permanent

Q5

A

1. The result will be announced by the board tomorrow.
2. The teacher told the students not to copy the answer.
3. No sooner had the officer arrived than the meeting began.
4. Unless you check the source, you may share an error.
5. The bag is too heavy for her to carry.
6. He is not only diligent but also careful.
7. In spite of the route being long, they continued walking.
8. shall we?
9. Being narrow, the road made the bus move slowly.
10. The chairperson signed only the minutes.

Accept grammatical equivalents that preserve the required transformation and meaning. In Q5A9, do not accept a dangling form that makes the bus the road's modifier.

B. Meaning, form and self-marking boundary

Word	Required form and meaning	Natural model sentence	Accept /​ reject
coherent	adjective: logical, connected and easy to follow	<i>The report presented a coherent account of the delay.</i>	Accept logical/​well-​connected; reject simply "loud" or "lengthy."
mitigate	transitive verb: make a harm, risk or severity less serious	<i>Shade trees can mitigate the effect of extreme heat.</i>	Accept correct verb inflections; reject "remove completely" or a noun used in place of the verb.
tentative	adjective: provisional, uncertain or not final	<i>The committee reached a tentative agreement pending review.</i>	Accept provisional/​uncertain; reject confident/​final.
resilient	adjective: able to recover, adapt or continue after difficulty	<i>The resilient network restored service after the disruption.</i>	Accept recovery/​adaptation sense; reject "fragile" or a merely strong physical object without recovery meaning.
obsolete	adjective: no longer current or useful because replaced	<i>The office replaced its obsolete filing system.</i>	Accept out-​of-​date/​superseded; reject merely old if it remains useful.

C

elicit, exceed, credible, effect, together

D. Meaning, form and self-marking boundary

Expression	Meaning and form	Natural model sentence	Accept /​ reject
Look before you leap.	proverb: consider consequences before acting	<i>Before accepting the contract, she compared its conditions; look before you leap.</i>	A complete proverb may stand alone; reject use praising impulsiveness.
a thorn in the flesh	noun phrase: a persistent source of irritation or trouble	<i>The recurring leak became a thorn in the administration's flesh.</i>	Accept enduring annoyance/​problem; reject a one-​time minor inconvenience.
know the ins and outs	verb phrase: know all the details of a system or matter	<i>The clerk knows the ins and outs of the application process.</i>	Accept detailed practical knowledge; reject a literal inside/​outside meaning.
Where there is a will, there is a way.	proverb: determination can help overcome obstacles	<i>They kept revising their plan because where there is a will, there is a way.</i>	A complete proverb may stand alone; reject a claim that desire guarantees success without effort.

Expression	Meaning and form	Natural model sentence	Accept /​ reject
go berserk	verb phrase: become wildly uncontrolled, angry or excited	<i>The crowd did not go berserk; it left the venue calmly.</i>	Accept an uncontrolled-​reaction sense; reject a casual synonym for "work hard" or "go quickly."